clue what it signifies. While Diwali, the Festival of Lights, has over the years become, in popular perception, the standout Hindu festival, it is observed fairly modestly in the south; in Kerala, on the other hand, the festival of Onam is celebrated with enormous gaiety and piety unlike in the north, where it is not celebrated at all.

Onam, in fact, offers another striking example of Hindu diversity. It celebrates the annual return to earth of the *asura* King Mahabali, a wise and benevolent monarch under whose egalitarian rule the people of Kerala flourished in mythical times. The gods, jealous of his overweening power and popularity, sent Lord Vishnu to earth in the form of a Brahmin dwarf, Vamana, who asked the king for as much land as he could cover in three steps. The king, surprised by the modesty of his request, granted his wish; whereupon the dwarf grew to his celestial size as the Lord. With one step he covered the earth, with his second the heavens; and when he had nowhere left to place his third step, he turned to the king to fulfil his promise. King Mahabali humbly offered his own head; Lord Vishnu placed his foot on the monarch's head, driving the king through the ground into the netherworld. Onam commemorates Mahabali's annual return to earth to see how his people are getting on. Rather like Santa Claus, he is largely portrayed as a jolly rotund figure happy to see his subjects enjoying a good time, and Onam is an occasion for holiday cheer, gift-giving and enormous feasts. As I have noted, it is, however, not celebrated by north Indian Hindus, who instead observe, the day before Onam, a minor festival called Vamana Puja in which they worship Vishnu in the form of a dwarf. A Malayalam tweet by a north Indian politician, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) President Amit Shah, wishing Keralites well on the occasion of Vamana Puja, caused great offence to its intended audience, since it was portrayed as celebrating the ill-treatment of the popular local king vanquished by Vamana!

As a result of its huge diversity, and the multiple folk religious practices it has absorbed over the millennia, mainstream Hinduism abounds in festivals. There is no day in the calendar which is not associated with some auspicious occasion, or dedicated to a specific god, or assigned to a particular religious practice. The importance and significance of each day will again vary depending on which part of